On-line Appendix

Excerpts with definition of luck from semistructured interviews

We report anonymized excerpts from each interview that refer to participants' open-ended responses to the question: *"So just in general – there is no correct answer: what do you think luck is for you? How do you understand it, how do you define luck?"* This question typically concluded the interview. In a few cases, a follow-up question was asked; when this contributed to the respondent's definition of luck, we included the follow-up question and answer. The question is identified with a Q. In a few other cases the participant provided spontaneous definitions of luck during the interview. We also report those excerpts in addition to the answer to the final question.

Each excerpt is presented along with the codes we assigned to it. Multiple codes may be applied to a single excerpt—for instance, an excerpt might refer to both a lack of control and contain counterfactual expressions, in which case both codes are assigned. For each quotation, we report both the reduced 6-category coding scheme and the more detailed 14-category scheme.

For example, in interview 1.1, the code "coincidence of events: right place, right time" indicates that the definition of luck was coded as *"right place, right time"* in the 14-category scheme, and as *"coincidence of events"* in the 6-category scheme. In some cases, an extended code coincides with a reduced one—for instance, *"Lack of control: lack of control"* refers to a definition of luck categorized as *"lack of control"* in both schemes. Conversely, *"lack of control: no merit/effort"* refers to an excerpt in which luck is defined in contrast to merit or effort; this is classified under *"lack of control"* in the reduced scheme. In cases where a code overlaps completely across the two tiers (e.g., *lottery of birth*), we report it only once.

For each excerpt, we indicate whether the student is a first- or second-generation interviewee and list the codes assigned to their definition of luck. Interview identifiers are presented in the format #.#.

Please refer to section 5.1 in the main text of the article for a full explanation of the coding framework.

01_1

Codes:
- 1st generation
- coincidence of events: right place time

Content:

> Yes, let's say, I think that it's difficult to say what is luck; in my view, of course it's like conjunctural moments in your life that happen if you are in the right moment, with the right people, in the right place, you can succeed at something.

01_2

Codes:
- 1st generation
- Lack of control: lack of control

Content:

> (silence) I mean… (silence) Luck is… How can I say… (laughs slightly)… Luck is like when you do something… Good question… (silence) How can I define it… I would say it is something that

is not totally under your control, so I would give an example… a practical example… if you shoot a ball and… you know… it's difficult (laughs slightly)… I would need to use a practical example, I can't think of one… But essentially is something you cannot control. You can do better or do worse, but it is something you cannot control… (silence) I don't know (silence)… Luck… Probably a good example would be lottery or something like that. But I would say… I would give an example of lottery or other type of games, if I had to explain it to a child… But there are also more complex things… Also, it depends on your own effort… I don't know, I can't find a smart way to say this thing.

02_1

Codes:
- 1
- residual: Don't know

Content:

What is luck??? (long pause and sighs) I don't know, like… I think it's...
Q:
There is no correct answer, just what do you think luck is, what it means for you?
A.
Like, you can find luck somehow. Like, not winning the lottery, yes, that's fucking random but…
Q:
So winning the lottery is not luck?
A.
Yes, yes, yes… but I don't know, yes there's luck but you just gave meaning to that thing. I don't know, I don't know.

02_2

Codes:
- Lack of control: randomness

Content:

Q: No, nothing to be sorry about. As I told you, there are no wrong answers. Actually, your answer gives me opportunity to ask you… if you consider that there is nothing particularly lucky in your life, could you give me a definition of luck? What is luck to you?

OK, this is a… this is a tricky question… To me, I would consider luck a randomness in events. What do I mean by this? Imagine that I have an exam and… my skills allow me to get a 16 out of 20. There is always randomness… I can get a 14, I can get a 17, 18… That difference between my actual skill and the result I actually got is what I consider luck, whether it's for the better or for the worse. To me that's it, random components in life that change the outcome regardless of your ability or the effort you actually made.

03_1

Codes:
- 1st generation
- coincidence of events: Independent events
- Lack of control: lack of control
- Ignorance of causes/Structural

Content:

Q. To conclude - this is very open, up to you - what is your understanding, what do you think about luck? Could you define what luck means for you?

(Laughs) I don't know any academic definition of luck, so I would just go with what I think is… it might be I don't know, like a combination of events you perceive as random or at least that are motivated by the lot of other things which do not depend on you, so you feel like there is something out of control that led to an outcome, and that this outcome was a positive one and so you kind of think that this outcome is delivered by luck. But I don't know if I answered the question actually. It's an astral conjuncture.

Q. OK so you believe in luck as an actual thing or is it just your interpretation?

No, I think I will still give it an interpretation. I think that many things could still be explained but in my eyes I don't know which things these are, so I interpret them as luck.

03_2

Codes:
- 2nd generation
- Counterfactual world
- Lack of control: lack of control
- Lack of control: randomness

Content:

I thought about this a lot. I have many answers for this and I could go on… I thought about luck a lot, actually. (silence) I mean… my thinking has been changing: I think, I think first luck, what people call luck, is kind of a relatively ill-defined thing. Luck, in the kind of luck day-to-day discourse calls being lucky sometimes, being lucky, is just like a combination of circumstances that are relatively out of your control and that you assign a positive value, for which the consequence of it you basically define something that is positive by opposition to a counterfactual world in which, if that thing wouldn't have happened, you would be in a worse situation. The problem is that you never know if you will be in a worse situation or not because you do not know the counterfactual. You cannot add an individual level, you cannot never know the counterfactual, so luck is kind of this… for me it's kind of is this ill-defined idea that has to do with randomness. So, I think that ultimately, luck has to do with these random events, whatever that means, that…. something that is… something that you cannot really control or that is out of your… that is out of your control and that you assign like a positive… or to which the consequences of this, you assign a positive value to it. You, you judge it positively, let's say. So yeah, I guess for me this is kind of what luck means, but… it's really interesting, then this leads to other discussions about exactly what you have control over and what you don't have control over… and what is this having control and this type of stuff, which ultimately lends leads to discussions about free will and whether free will exists… and I tend to think that free will is not a real thing, so, I don't know, I wouldn't go through this now, this would lead to a much longer conversation.

04_1

Codes:
- 1st generation
- Lottery of birth

Content:

Q. OK - so just in general - there is no correct answer: what do you think is luck for you? How do you understand it, how do you define luck?

A. I don't know, I mean… I don't know whether I should call it luck or not but I always thought that if you have a really good family background - both in personality, education, and financial - you might end up in a really good place. Because once I met someone, you are at the same age and I was studying [language] in order to improve my [language] because I studied it for like two years - and I met a girl in a conference (she's also [nationality]) and her [language] was perfect and I asked her: how did you learn that? She replied: my family lived one year in [country], one year in [country], I mean six months in [country], so I studied [language] there… For me I thought that might be luck, because even though you study or you spend a lot of time, sometimes there is a really easy way to do that, at that point I mean you can call it money or family or something else, or you can call it luck. So that is my definition of luck.

05_1

Codes:

- 2nd generation
- Lack of control: lack of control
- Lack of control: randomness

Content:

Q. What is luck for you, how do you define it, how do you understand it?

Sometimes I had this idea that luck really doesn't exist, and that you build your own luck, like meeting people, starting to learn something, then you realize that this kind of idea that you are the owner of your own life and you decide what to do. But I don't believe that anymore because there is a component of luck in the end. I don't know someone you randomly meet that can save your life or regarding studies or work sometimes you're also a little bit lucky… For example my friends with similar studies, but you can see like one who is more active/proactive finds a better job or higher salary than one that is less proactive. But also there is this luck of that is also at the same time the one who's proactive is in a sector who's growing a lot and increasing a lot so of course he has some merit, because he's moving around, meeting people, looking for a new job… but at the same time it's a growing sector, so it's difficult to disentangle up to what point he's lucky or he's also putting some effort, you know.

Q. Can you identify in general any of these lucky events like you said like you met a random person they gave you advice or something like that that happened to you?

I guess its randomness in the end like it's something you cannot control and sometimes you're lucky sometimes you're unlucky, sometimes something happens that helps you, sometimes something happens that doesn't help you, but in the end of course there are things you cannot control, you can say "oh how unlucky I am or how lucky I am" but not everything you have control in your entire life. There are things that are out of your control and sometimes… me for example I think I was lucky with the fact that [name of supervisor] came this year you know, I think he's an amazing supervisor and I feel super lucky with him, these kind of things but that's completely luck, I could not control this kind of things.

05_2

Codes:

- 1st generation
- Lack of control: No merit/ no effort

Content:

When you say you're lucky, you did nothing to earn it, you know, like, of course it's related with the concept of merit. Someone that has planned something and has put effort and has tried to create the conditions for something to happen to him or her, this is not luck....

...Luck is all those things that you fewer merit on. And maybe gets of course more complicated when you talk about money and social class and family, because, like, you don't do anything to be born in the family that you are, but you have the resources of that background, and I know like some friends on my village, they had a terrible background in terms of family… abusive parents and things like that, and they've had… And we had this discussion about the frustration and saying like "I would like to not have to deal with this right now, so I can think if I want to go to university, which scholarship do I have to take"… all those kind of things. And I did not have this problem. You know, I didn't have to deal with my parents, police or or abuse or moving because my dad is an alcoholic or things like that. I did not have to deal with any of that so that I was lucky. So, I could try, you know. A nice straight path to what I wanted to do, but other people don't. So, it's like this merit you know, I was lucky that I had this environment, but I also have a strong merit component I cannot take off… you know, it's like clear work, I worked a lot to make money to go to Erasmus or to other places. Because my parents were clear with that, like "We will help you as much as we can we but can help you with only that, so if this is enough for you, good. If it is not enough for you, you will have to find the means on your own". So this having clear, what I could do or not, also helped me planning on this. It could also be the other way around, that I didn't know and that I would end up broke and dropping out of school. But this didn't happen.

06_1

Codes:
- 2nd generation
- Lack of control: lack of control

Content:

Q. More generally, what is luck for you, can you define it for us?

An object of anxiety that one needs to learn to coexist with. This is the best definition I can come up with: an object of anxiety that one needs to learn, because you don't have control over it and there are many things in life that you have no control over them, so yeah otherwise…. I'm not a positive person and I don't like to think of myself that… precisely because I cannot have any kind of control over it, I cannot know exactly what luck is. But then if such a thing as luck exists, then we must accept that people make themselves and that there is a kind of self-determination in their own becoming, and honestly I do not think that this is the case… this is not the case at all, so I don't know. Things are in this liminal space between being totally determined or not or you making/becoming your own self with what you have. See again it's not much luck but yeah that's… What is luck for me yeah I like that if I think about the circumstances I'm in and whether I can control them or not or whether I can determine them or not. I'm basically forcing myself not to think of my circumstances.

06_2

Codes:
- 1st generation

○ Lottery of birth

Content:

> Yeah, I think when I understood your questions and you said like is there something, some event, you could point to where you got lucky… It almost sounded less like, you know, kind of the stars align and somehow some like fluke happens. But I think when I think of luck it's more, you know, these kind of conditions which allowed me to pursue what I wanted to pursue to, you know, be happy. The fact that I… That… I had such a supportive mother who, you know, would do everything she could to provide for us and make sure we could study… Yeah, I guess helped… The fact that during the [health condition], you know, it was obviously difficult, but I was able to go through therapy and get through, which I think is also not, you know, obvious for a lot of people. I think I got lucky in finding a good therapist and actually being able to go there. So yeah, I think when I see luck it's more this kind of basic things that you have but you kind of get born into them luckily, whereas just with the same chances are that if you didn't have them, it would have had a negative impact or if you wouldn't have had the potential to go on and do anything.

07_1

Codes:

○ 1st generation
○ Lack of control: lack of control
○ Lack of control: randomness

Content:

> Q. Okay, last question, open - no correct answer - more generally, what is luck for you, how would you define luck, how do you interpret it?
>
> To me… I'm a very shy person, I'm not the kind of people that says "you get what you deserve", but you can work and you can make that more likely, but luck is a product of chance many times, that you can't control, so… I believe that for me luck is: things that happen you can maximise or minimise, and… well, whose impact you can minimise or maximise, and then it's a product of… your actual willingness to catch the train or look for another option.

07_2

Codes:

○ 1st generation
○ Lack of control: lack of control

Content:

> I guess for me it's like… It's really difficult, I think. I think for me, maybe luck is if you can make it or can do something against all odds, you know like if it was not all like if it happened, yeah, I don't know… It's very difficult… Maybe not… Maybe it's more like… Like the serendipity or something… You know, you run into a person that then can help you with something... Maybe that's good luck… Like I think it's really difficult to define… I guess this this is, yeah, I would say something like that where you maybe run into a person or into a situation, even if it seemed to be difficult and you can make the best out of it. Or like not even that, but I guess like an encounter or something or situation that you've gotten in without really trying that then turned out to be positive. Maybe, but it's really difficult. I don't know how to define it. I guess I could a serendipity, like meeting someone. That is, or like being born into a situation or being raised in a situation, or having you know all of that, something that you can't really control, but it happens anyways to you

that turns out to be positive, I guess. That would maybe define luck. I don't know. Yeah. Something that you don't have control over, but end turns out to be positive.

08_1

Codes:
- 2nd generation
- Lack of control: randomness

Content:

So I think luck for me is kind of random event or at least an event that has some random elements to it, and that brings you a positive result that helps you along in your life. It doesn't need to be like a positive result in the sense of like "I'm gonna be better at school afterwards" or something like that, but at least it's kind of… makes you more confident in your choices and maybe… maybe it also brings you to a certain place that you wouldn't have been without. It's difficult to describe, it's a difficult question.

08_2

Codes:
- 2nd generation
- Lack of control: randomness

Content:

A random event. I think the interpretation of luck is really related with the personality of the person. I think it's about whether you are possibly like more positive person or not, or more of a negative person. Also, even your self-esteem, you know, like I think there are people that consider lucky events things that, of course, there's always like a kind of a random component, but maybe has more to do with the effort and their own… you know, themselves rather than luck components. The same with the negative things that happen. At the end I think it's… It really matters the personality of the person. Even I don't know, I could even think, you know, like if something goes wrong because… not doing well in a thing. It may be sometimes a way to don't feel guilty or not assume responsibilities. So… I mean it's… for sure there is randomness in the world. But I think after what extent is more a matter of how you want to deal with reality.

09_1

Codes:
- 2
- Coincidence of events: right place time
- Lack of control: randomness

Content:

I would say… that random variation that allows you to be there in the moment it has to be, and not a little bit before or a little bit after… Or being in the place you need to be, and not a little bit to the left or to the right… Random variation. I guess it's all pretty endogenous, but that little… that little allows some variance, which has become difficult for me to identify.

09_2

Codes:
- 2nd generation
- Residual: other

Content:

I think luck is, yeah... Like I said, it's something arbitrary. So, it's something that there's no real reason behind it necessarily, right? There's no… you can't find a reason for explaining why… so luck is it's… it's… It's like an arbitrary stroke of… I don't know of goodness, in a way. So that there's no real reason why something good is happening to someone but something does happen and… yeah, but there's no larger justification for it. It's kind of… yeah, it's like an arbitrary goodness, I would say. It's arbitrary goodness.

10_1

Codes:
- 1st generation
- Lack of control: lack of control
- Lottery of birth

Content:

eah… I guess there are factors in life that you have control over and there's a lot more factors in life that you don't have control over. So in any case luck pertains to the latter category, where a serendipitous decision or event that is not under your control contributes in a positive way to strengthening your opportunities, or giving you a new opportunity that you would otherwise haven't had, or facilitating a decision you made yourself, pursuing the goals you set out for yourself, let's say, I guess that's luck.
But I don't think luck ex… - like, you need to recognize something as luck as well and I don't think luck exists in a vacuum and it always requires a certain mental attitude towards your life, towards the decisions you're faced with, in order for someone to be able to recognize something as lucky. I guess there's a lot more like personality than luck but surely… yeah, lucky I didn't grow up below the poverty line, lucky I never lived in an armed conflict, lucky privilege, yeah, tons of privilege. So yeah that's a huge luck factor, and I'm not even… clearly I'm not the most privileged of the privileged categories, but I'm very well aware of just the privilege of growing up in a country where the threshold for participating in higher education is pretty low, we have huge participation in [name of country] which is great, quality education, good social services, so it's easy for people in xx [name of country] to pursue higher education if they want to. Luckily my mom found her way to xx [name of country], found a way to stay, met my dad, made me… and that's how I got to do my studies.

10_2

Codes:
- 2nd generation
- Lottery of birth

Content:

So, to me again, I think it's a bit connected to what I said for the previous question. So, if I want to define luck in relation to life in general, I think it's more of this connection to… to… to… to privilege, on the one hand, then, perhaps, to health and to how your relationships developed. So, these two or three aspects, rather this than, for example, winning a lottery. So, in a conceptual

sense, I think more of this metaphysical conception of luck is how I think about it in life term sense, yeah.

11_1

Codes:
- 2nd generation
- Lack of control: lack of control
- Lack of control: randomness

Content:

Luck… I think there is a fair amount of randomness in everybody's life. They can't be controlled and sometimes this randomness give you things that are somehow unexpected. Sometimes the unexpected is positive, sometimes it's negative. I think it's a very instrumental definition to call luck "the randomness that gives us unexpected positive things". That's good luck. Bad luck would be "the randomness that gives us some negatives".

11_2

Codes:
- 2nd generation
- Other: Ignorance of causes/Structural
- Other: other

Content:

I would give a vague answer which would go like this I think: I think etymologically luck and happiness are related. I think in other Germanic languages actually happy stands for luck. So, I always find that interesting somehow. I never really dug into that, but I think it's interesting the idea of… maybe fate or fortune smiling on you. I think… I was reading this book recently by Charles Tilly called "Durable inequality" and he said that the standard Western narrative is kind of an individualistic one, so people may tend to see structural events or features more in terms of luck that when the external imposes itself on your subjective experience, when you have this individualistic experience, the experience of the structural can seem like luck but maybe it's not. So, for example, having this supervisor in the Masters programme who knew about the EUI maybe was lucky. But perhaps by the structures of society I was set up to be lucky in some way, in any way. So yeah, terms for defining luck… I can't really.

12_1

Codes:
- 1st generation
- Coincidence of events: Independent events
- Other: Ignorance of causes/Structural

Content:

Luck? For me, again, I'm a very structuralist person, so for me luck is… obviously there is a lot of luck, but in in terms of life directories… I like to think that luck is what we don't understand. Yeah, what we don't understand.

Q.
So it doesn't exist really such a thing?

Yeah, I have this feeling. But also that also I think that we tend to post-rationalize everything. So something happens. And then you tend to, so people tend to rationalize that thing. So "I choose that. I choose whatever. I choose this path because of something you rationalize after the event". So it's difficult for me to say. I have the feeling that this counterfactual of me working in the car shop doesn't exist. But I don't know, it could happen. It could happen. If the job market was better it could have been. And the luck exists in this case.

Q. And what about the counterfactual of you continuing to play football, for example, with this group of people and not going abroad?

Yes, but no. This counterfactual is more plausible I would say. Because in the end, you spend more time with people from the neighborhood who have these lower income jobs or this kind of manual, routine jobs. And it's easier that you get into these jobs basically because you know these people and these people recommend you or they recommend. You know, you will know the existence of these deals and then... And I didn't answer your question. What is luck for me? Like in general in social science I would, I would say, yeah, obviously there is some unrelated events, super unrelated, that become luck to some extent. That's my thinking. So the causal chain is so, so long that you can say are unrelated. But still I think there is a causal chain, you know.

12_2

Codes:
- 2nd generation
- Low probability: Unexpected event

Content:

My biased definition of luck, because it's the one that I tend to push every day or like to push in a general sense, is basically those… I mean, I have clear in mind, but I don't have clear in words, but basically it's like you are pursuing a path and by this path that you are pursuing, you can do it harder or lower in intensity, but there are the elements that accompany you without a clear causal link between your acts that accompany… like for example, the scholarship to go abroad. I mean, I worked hard and my path was to continue with my studies and I was lucky that because of X considerations they brought me. I just think it's… So, those elements that you find during your career that without the causal relation with you, helps you unexpectedly and makes you… it's a positive impact into you and your continued development.

13_1

Codes:
- 2nd generaion
- Lack of control: lack of control
- Lack of control: randomness

Content:

I was thinking that that people must define it really differently. Because if it's very difficult for me to think an event, it's really difficult to try and go back to my memory and see what would be an event, and so we probably all define it - other than going back and finding the wallet, I think that's a very clear example – but I don't know. I think maybe I'm a people person, 'cause I was thinking all my examples are about other people, like how luck is related to that other person in my life instead of an event that has, I don't know, like an outside event that is lucky for me. I don't know, uh, how would I define it? Something kind of… not completely out of your power because we

affect any, everything and anything, even if we don't want to or try to. But considering all the path dependency then the luck would be a factor that was not… You couldn't… It wasn't… You can't control it, or it's a situation that was out of your control, out of your power, and out of your influence in a way. But it doesn't mean that someone is doing something in your life and you can have no control over it because it's like a random factor added. I think that's a very simple definition. It's like a random factor.

13_2

Codes:
- ○ 1st generation
- ○Coincidence of events: Independent events

Content:

Uh, I guess… when… A kind of the… The combination… a combination of like a combination of external factors… that allow a person to succeed in a given situation.

14_1

Codes:
- ○ 2nd generation
- ○ Lack of control: No merit/ no effort

Content:

I think luck is something that is, uh, exogenous to your actions. No, it's not something that you, uh, it's not the result of an effort or an action that you take, is something that just appears or not. Positive shock.

14_2

Codes:
- ○ 2nd generaion
- ○ Lack of control: lack of control
- ○ Lottery of birth
- ○ Low probability: unlikely event

Content:

Like I said, I wouldn't also name the same thing, which is my family, my parents. Lucky to not come out of a broken home, to have both of my parents also, still alive… A lot of my… almost all of my friends have lost one of their parents already. So that I consider myself very lucky to still have both of them. Uhm… Moments of luck... No, not really, I think. But it's maybe also because, I mean, some things depend on how you define luck also… But my supervisor, actually at the EUI, once said which I very much agree with, which is "luck happens to those who merit it". So, I don't know, if something went well, then I don't think I would, you know, completely attribute that to being lucky because I put in the work… or I made it happen for a specific reason. The only thing I could not choose was my parents. That's why, I you know, I attributed that to luck… my family, how they raised me… But yeah, I don't think I can name anything else.

Q: OK, OK. So, the final question you kind of already touched upon it… But if I ask you to define luck, to give me definition of luck, what can you say?

I guess… To have something happen or to receive something, to be able to do something that you otherwise… or are very unlikely to receive, do or happen.

15_1

Codes:
- 2nd generation
- Lack of control: randomness

Content:

Something super random. OK, something you cannot expect and you cannot probably further explain as something systematic, right? So something really random in that sense. Yes, and which has positive implications.

15_2

Codes:
- 2nd generation
- Lack of control: lack of control

Content:

This is hard, to put it in few words! Like, what is luck in the end? In the meanwhile, I used some metaphors like a helping hand or something like that… And then the question is, do you create your luck in the end? Is it something given? To everybody equally, let's say? And then we make use of it, or we provoke it or, you know? What is luck? Luck, luck is… Something out of your control, we can say… But given from whom in the end? Because I'm not very religious, so I won't use any theological terms, God or something… I think luck is out there, I think that some people attract and repulse luck as well. It just happens… from stories you hear… Some people are unlucky, they can't help it somehow, everything goes wrong for a reason. But also I believe very much in agency, so luck is just complimentary, it's mostly your effort and what you do, and then luck comes into play as a… not a protagonist, but as a second actor.

16_1

Codes:
- 1st generation
- Lack of control: lack of control
- Lack of control: randomness

Content:

I don't know. As I said, luck is random stuff that you cannot control. It's out of your control. So it could be good or bad, depends on how it affects you. And yeah, it's I think it's everything that's out of your control, everything that happens around you that you cannot react properly or… because you don't have the awareness to do it… or that others do that affects you. That's luck, because you cannot decide of… I mean, most of the time the world is completely random for me, like you don't have to make a complex hypothesis of what happened, of these people thinking of… It's just people acting and that's it. That's luck. Maybe 99% of the time the things that happen in the world is luck. For me is like that, you know?

16_2

Codes:

- 2nd generation
- Lack of control: No merit/ no effort

Content:

> OK, uhm. I would say luck is having something happen. Or receiving something when you are not meritorious of it, but you got it anyway. Or when you are in the pool of people, say 500 applicants equally qualified, and it could be any of the 500 and it happens to be you. That would be my understanding of luck.

17_1

Codes:

- 2nd generation
- Lack of control: lack of control

Content:

> In that, despite your best or your worst efforts, something happens that favors you. I think that's how I could define it.

17_2

Codes:

- 2nd generation
- Lottery of birth
- Lack of control: lack of control

Content:

> **Starting with the lottery of birth, you know, being born in xx to, you know, loving parents, you know, and not having any major health conditions throughout my life, … I mean, I'm incredibly privileged in so many ways, and that's pure luck...**
>
> ...Right, gosh, you know, my head is trying to remember Locke and egalitarianism and all these theories. But I mean, my definition of luck… you know, I guess… Very intuitively, off the top of my head, luck is… Are those forces that are completely outside of your control, right? Good luck or bad luck, you know, but those are things… is sort of this idea of force majeure, something that you can't really do much about these things. And I think, yeah, that would probably be my definition of luck. Something that you have very little to no, no control over.

18_1

Codes:

- 1st generation
- Lottery of birth

Content:

> Pretty much everything, where you're born, your state, what your parents were doing before you were born, all of these things, like you can't choose how you are born into the world? I was certainly lucky to be one of them and have a good life in Western Europe.

18_2

Codes:

- 2nd generation

- Coincidence of events: Independent events

Content:

I would say luck is, and I'm looking very much at my own biography obviously, Luck is in the way that combination of factors align in a certain way, certain particular moment that lifts you and the result is beyond your average capability. So, I would not consider myself lucky, because I did a master's because I know this generally, in average, in my intellectual background it is average to do it, so it is not luck to be able to do a master's for me. But it was luck, in the sense that certain things aligned, certain moment that you jump higher than you actually could and that is luck. And, of course, it's in more general terms it's… it's the absence of any grave, let's say, external shock, external meaning of course also health related that completely messes up your life and changes all your plans and imposes itself. The most important thing I can, I mean, my brother suffering from [health condition], for eight years now… And we are not super close, but of course I can see what's happening to him, he is doing alright, but not super... This stuff happens to people as well at age, what was he, 23, right? And then you keep... you become always dedicated to the disease. And I'm dedicated just to whatever comes to my mind, so I'm that… maybe looking at him, yeah, I'm lucky that I… these things didn't struck me. So, there's a more, let's say, punctual definition and a more general definition… And I've been quite blessed by both, I think. I hope that's OK.

19_1

Codes:

- 2
- Coincidence of events: Independent events
- Lack of control: randomness
- Lottery of birth

Content:

Yeah, that's why it was hard to reply to the question. So I think… luck defines the position, like the choices that you can, that you have available. So it defines the positions from which you start. That's why the first reply was OK, I was born in that city, in that family and that for me was lucky because I could have been born in a remote island, in a very poor family with no option to study. And then I think, so, these options, which is what determines luck or unluck, the kind of options that you see in front of you, it's determined by randomic events, and when they combine in a way that the options that you see are more favorable then it's luck. Otherwise, it's unluck. I don't think it's a dictionary definition, but that's it.

19_2

Codes:

- 2
- Lack of control: randomness

Content:

I have thought about this thing of different types luck… Probably because there's a… I think the best definition I got from my readings and so on is sort of like chance plus consequence, as well some fortuitous, like, not completely determined event happening and this has good or bad consequences and then that's good or bad luck… So, in the end, the easiest would be, you know, you win the lottery or whatever, but that's very easy because that's almost as probabilistic in nature, just like numbers… In your life, I mean, I think this last example that I gave is very hard to tell because it's hard to say what is a good thing or a bad thing, you know? And this changes a lot over the course of your life. So, I think in general, any definition will have to be sort of constrained

within the moment, you know, a system of values that exists now and might change after. So again, I said when these things were happening, I felt horrible "This is terrible. This is so bad". Now, I'm like, it's actually turned out to be good. It's actually nice. What just said about PhD blah blah, I consider myself happy and lucky, but maybe, you know, this will cause some major depression like many people who do a PhD then feel miserable and say "This was the worst thing ever. Fuck this professor who taught me in high school", you know? So, I think it's, in that sense, there's a sort of fundamental difficulty in the finding what is good or bad... But so, and I think the solution there is just to define it in time, you know, like now this… I consider this a good event, you know, or to pick sort of very obvious outcomes if you're thinking of it as a matter of study… you get a teacher degree, yes or no? I mean, we can all agree that this is overall something good, then it can be specific anecdotes and people for whom it turns out to be bad because they wanted to be hippies or they want it to be… I don't know, whatever, entrepreneurs and whatnot. So, I think yeah, the best definition, some combination of, you know, chance event plus consequences, good or bad. The difficulty I think is in determining, yeah, what extent, good or bad, especially once we go into outcomes, there are not, you know, education and so on. And also, chance event, I think also what we said, what I've been talking about is also there is always a component of to what extent do you make your own luck, right? Because again, lottery is a pure logic event, but, you know, some events that I had in my life and so on like they were luck, but they were... It's as if my path was in some ways restricted, you know? It's like, so some things happen out of luck, but because you're also in that situation and you know how to use that situation to your advantage and so on… So, it's… even the chance part is not super obvious, I would say. Sorry, I went super long. Maybe, maybe just chance plus outcome, sorry, consequences is a good definition.

20_1

Codes:
- 2nd generation
- Coincidence of events: right place time

Content:

To me luck is really is this very nice combination of being in the right moment, in the right place and feeling like doing this or that. Because, for example, you can… I would say, sure, you can get an acceptance letter from the EUI, let's say, but you also must feel like taking this chance. You must perceive it as being a chance, and only then it becomes luck. Yeah, I think luck is quite of a hard concept to grasp.

20_2

Codes:
- 1st generation
- Coincidence of events: independent events
- Lack of control: randomness

Content:

Uhm… (silence) I would define it as… Like… kind of a... A random event that happens in your favor. And that… It could only happen because of a lot of things around it that just worked for you at one point in time. Yeah, I'd define it this way.

21_1

Codes:

- 2nd generation
- Lottery of birth
- Other: dont believe in luck

Content:

I don't believe in luck. If you're wealthy enough, you can create your own luck, and the surroundings can be shaped according to your wealth, let's say. I believe in manifestation: I think people can create their luck through wanting something so bad and like working for it. But I believe in lucky moments. Sometimes things cannot be controlled through you or your family or your friends or you know, your surroundings, because probably they serve for a bigger picture in your life, you know? I believe that everything happens for a reason. But luck? I was born lucky, because my family is like wealthy enough, you know? I have a lovely family. So, I was lucky in that sense.

21_2

Codes:

- 2nd generation
- Lack of control: lack of control
- Lottery of birth

Content:

When there's a positive outcome that you absolutely could not… Like nothing like the… OK, nothing that you consciously did towards a positive outcome and... Nothing you could possibly do towards the positive outcome had any actual influence on the positive outcome. For me that will be it. Like, just, you know, something good happens without you actively pursuing it. But then again… Yeah, like… Where does, where does luck start? I mean, I'm a white male, European, Central European born, probably not the stupidest guy. You know, I think I was born lucky and then, like, you know, just the fact that I'm not dead yet just means that I'm also lucky.

22_1

Codes:

- 1st generation
- Lack of control: No merit/ no effort
- Lack of control: randomness

Content:

Like randomness or arbitrariness. In a more personal setting, like, getting something positive, I guess, if it's luck, not bad luck, out of nowhere, just by chance. Like, without doing anything to deserve it or not deserve it just because. You were there, you didn't know about that and you just got the opportunity or whatever.

22_2

Codes:

- 2nd generation
- Coincidence of events: right place time
- Lottery of birth

Content:

How would I define luck?... Luck is making the right choices without realizing all the context tomorrow. Luck can be described as just being at the right place at the right time, like… Sorry I'm a bit tired. Luck is… well, from my story also being healthy enough to do actually whatever you want to do. And also surrounded by proper people. I think I ran of what is luck answers.

23_1

Codes:
- 2nd generation
- Low probability: unexpected event

Content:

A sudden, unexpected, unstructured event.

01_3

Codes:
- 1st generation
- Lack of control: lack of control
- Low probability: unlikely event

Content:

Um... something that's outside one's control. Something that is positive. And also something that is unlikely to happen. Or that's involved a lot of coincidence, like something statistically unlikely.

02_3

Codes:
- 1st generation
- Coincidence of events: Independent events

Content:

Yeah I don't know it's it's I guess it's just a kind you know, star alignment you know. I would say so like you know obviously like society and things we do is just it's just it's just this network of many different factors of many different trajectories you know. And sometimes they align simply you know. But you need to keep pushing you know you need to help luck. You know with this preparation you know just like itself it's not gonna it's not it's not gonna get you I mean yes you can win lottery sure. That's that's pure luck I guess that's the purest form of luck I guess. But still even with that you need to try you need to buy the coupon you know you need to buy the tickets in order to win. So it's always, so I always think of luck as it's kind of like constellation of things. That you know you need to keep pushing out and then at one point the consolation of these trajectories is aligned you know.

03_3

Codes:
- 1st generation
- Low probability: unlikely event

Content:

I think luck is such a difficult thing. First we would rather want it to be exogeneous. It needs to be something with low probability. It needs to, there are so many constrains. It's also difficult because of the constrains we could also say that... To either say that everything is luck. Where you come from, where you are being born. The probability of being born in a very specific family is minuscule. So, saying like some random counter, for example, I can understand the people who says they have a mentor call that lucky. But I've never had a mentor in my life. Yeah is that a lucky or an unlucky event? Cause like all of my friends more or less have had mentors but I've never had a mentor. Is that like unluck? It's also weird because it's OK if you're in a social network in a social dynamics where most people have mentors, and you don't. How do we define that? On the average, if we think about the population, I don't think that the majority has they have a mentor when they're 16–17–18. But what is the population that you're actually interested? Like should probably be relative to your social position. And then it comes out, ok, am I unlucky because I haven't had mentor? Yeah, luck needs to be contextualized cause otherwise some things are lucky for people with less resources but are normal for people within these resources. Yeah that is what I want to add, context matters in the definition of luck.

04_3

Codes:
- 2nd generation
- Lack of control: lack of control

Content:

I think luck for me is something that you couldn't necessarily foresee or control which happens and effects you personally. Where after well both in a moment maybe but especially after like short while you realize well this actually helped me or make me happier or maybe you know somebody that is now bringing lots of happiness into my life. Like have some some positive aspect. But like it's not directly linked to your choice so I think this is to me the definition. Like some exogenous, I'll pass into economics terminology now, some exogenous event happening and affecting you that you don't really have any control over which either in the moment or later on you come to realize actually had a very positive outcome on most of your personal wellbeing. Like this can be linked to academic achievement this can be linked to not diying or stuff like that.

05_3

Codes:
- 2nd generation
- Counterfactual world
- Lack of control: lack of control
- Lottery of birth

Content:

That's a great question. I guess luck is a situation where there is a very... It's like one of the alternatives paths is very much preferable to the other ones and you're not the one who is control of which path you take. Something like that. So working definition....I mean maybe it's it's bad form for an interviewee to kind of try to intervene with the research project but I just want to mention that my both my parents were literary they had literal degrees. I mean it's not like they pushed me to read my sister and my sister when I was in diapers, but they were kind of still kind of in all kinds of ways kind of soft pushing me towards academia. Just by having full bookshelves at home the kind of stuff I did so the reason I got into academics was because I was really into reading and because I was into reading because of the family I got from so so that's kind of more cosmic luck. But I think there's definitely a class element even though we were quite poor and in

some ways working class the cultural capital in the classical sense was really high. And that's kind of what it's like a list of like criteria, like grade point averages and applications and on every single level that kind of that kind of background advantage was kind of pushing up.

06_3

Codes:
- 1st generation
- Lack of control: randomness

Content:

Like I mean yeah you remember there's these sort of rainbow colored things that give you a speed boost? So and so you're in the driver seat and sometimes luck for me is hitting one of these big boots because this is a bit random right? There's a lot of other cars and there's all kinds of things happening and the whole thing reacts very very quickly to whatever you do. Sometimes you get to them and sometimes not, and that in the end kinda decides whether you get third place or first place or 7th place. And of course your driving skill kind of matters or it's your overall say genetic biographical and cultural and social makeup. That certainly matters that's the basics your driving skills but maybe let's but then there's these kind of events that that you attend or don't attend. Or the seminars you attend or don't attend that really kind of shape the trajectory. And since you run on a certain track there's not only one but several of these speed boosts but you can get very unlucky and miss all of them. And I guess that's unlucky but you can also get very lucky and hit every single one of them, but say if I had not attended a seminar it might be a random choice that did not know the post-doc or the professor then. Had I had I not attended this this would have never happened right? Um and of course me being sort of academically capable meant that I could actually make use of this but it is in many ways random in the sense that it's a completely uninformed choice that I took this seminar. Neither through my system or clever decision making or ability that I ended up there, and not elsewhere. And at the same time, the religion teacher thing is the same thing. Though you get assigned decisions get assigned classes and more or less random and yeah that's kind of how I think about discussions and then there's the matter personal perfect of the Mario Kart right but sometimes you need to perhaps make wanted the third, uh, the first three places to qualify for the next round or something right. And if you happen to be fourth because you missed this one speed bump, a speed speed boost and you might just not qualify for the next round. And then things can start to diverge quite rapidly. Um see I did something I think about it.

07_3

Codes:
- 1st generation
- Coincidence of events: Independent events
- Lack of control: lack of control
- Low probability: unlikely event

Content:

In a very broad sense when things are out of your control, but still turn out well. In a way. Umm. Lucky… Especially if there's a small chance that will happen. Sometimes its beyond your control, but bound to happened, but there's bit of luck involved. It can go wrong, but in the end it went… well, that's lucky… Just coincidences, just things you got out of some good out of it, but it's really not for what you did but for how things worked, how things interacted.

08_3

Codes:
- 2nd generation
- Counterfactual world

Content:

> Uh, luck. I would say that it is when, on the contrary, um it's just one thing happen.. And, it's a hard question. Um, yeah I would say something functions or some something like an event happens and that could change the course of a predictable process and so yeah it it could potentially change a bit or a lot the course of a predictable process that you can explain.

10_3

Codes:
- 1st generation
- Low probability: unexpected event

Content:

> That's another interesting question. I always thought what is the definition of happiness and now I'm thinking of luck. Luck is uh when something unexpected occurs and changes your perspective. And yeah and it's like in my case, it invites you to think differently and to act differently. Yeah.

11_3

Codes:
- 2nd generation
- Lottery of birth

Content:

> Yeah maybe including qualities that you are born with that maybe make you stand out from people in your context. So if you're um maybe if you if you have like a different perception or different cognitive abilities. Um if your parents themselves were like that stood out from their community. I'm not answering this well.

12_3

Codes:
- 1st generation
- Other: other

Content:

> o have bad luck is bad things or keep on happening to you. You have good luck, good things keep happening to you. It’s very simple.

13_3

Codes:
- 2nd generation

- Low probability: unlikely event

Content:

> Luck is literally when you want something and you I have this very deep feeling that I would have. If something happened it would be really good for me and also for other people around me sometimes. And it happens, so maybe the odds are against you or maybe it's, it's you know what it is not so easy because there's a lot of circumstances that might play against you. And it somehow it still happens that's luck. I'm very lucky.

14_3

Codes:

- 2nd generation
- Coincidence of events: right place time
- Lack of control: randomness

Content:

> Luck? I guess it's just like randomness. By chance sometimes something happens and it's lucky or unlucky or neutrally lucky if that's a thing. Being at the right place at the right time.

15_3

Codes:

- 2nd generation
- Other: other

Content:

> I think luck is when you're given a chance and you're in a position to take it. Yeah, so I wanted to enter the EUI and there was somebody who didn't want to enter the EUI. So it was perfect 'cause there was a chance that I could take. Unluck is when either you don't get a chance, or you get a chance but you're not in a position to take it. Like what happened to me in [name of city], yes I could have lived there, but it was not possible for me. So the opportunity was there, but I did not have the setup, I didn't have the circumstances to accept it.

16_3

Codes:

- 2nd generation
- Coincidence of events: right place time
- Lottery of birth

Content:

> I mean it's it's it's it's something happen something right happens at the right moment. Because yeah it's not, for example the medication if I would have taken it two years earlier, I probably wouldn't have had these high grades to go to [prestigious school]. Despite on average having better grades, probably I wouldn't have had the higher grades in the semester directly before [prestigious school] because I would have already habituated to the drugs. You know so it's really, it's just the right thing happening at the right moment I would say. I mean in the end in my life things kinda worked out although... This is certainly reason'd why I have somewhat privileged social position because of my father's relative success and...

17_3

Codes:
- 2nd generation
- Other: other

Content:

> As I told you, for me luck is preparation meeting opportunity but it's also made of many other, many many other things.

18_3

Codes:
- 2nd generation
- Lack of control: No merit/ no effort
- Lottery of birth

Content:

> Uh. This is so difficult. Uhh... I guess... I have not thought about it deeply, this is an immediate response. I guess luck is something coincidental... I've not had a direct impact in making it happen. For example, being born in Sweden. Unlucky again... That it was not something, a consequence of something I've done... So for example, when my parents were struggling so much financially when I was growing up. Then of course, we can have a philosophical discussion about if there is such a thing as luck... Ah... And luck, it's just a matter of good preparation and to know when cease when the opportunity approaches... You know, all this sort of stuff. And... I think, I lean more towards... I think a lot of people who are very well off, they don't deserve the things they have. Also, a lot of this can be ascribed to luck... And, so... I guess... I think if I finding a note in the street that to me is just luck. It's not me having done anything, I didn't seek it out. But... I think that goes to the same thing, being born in Sweden or not having dyslexia for example.

19_3

Codes:
- 2nd generation
- Coincidence of events: right place time

Content:

> Being in a good situation and meeting the right people in the right time. Um yeah I think this is something that it's super important that this is the people who create luck. Perhaps in my situation or in my perspective it is like like that without them I think, it wouldn't be possible. And to see how that works. For some projects or academic projects especially or work if I haven't met my friend, I wouldn't have my job additional job apart from the PhD project.

21_3

Codes:
- 1st generation
- Coincidence of events: right place time

Content:

These kind of favorable circumstances in a particular moment. When you can be in that right place at the right moment that is luck.

22_3

Codes:
- 1st generation
- Low probability: unlikely event

Content

A philosophical debate now... Luck yeah I guess some kind of event or circumstance that ends up benefiting you in the end. You know something you not expected or unexpected that by virtue of it having happened and you're entering or you ended up being better off in the process.

Q: Do you think it needs to be like a chance event?

It can be anything I would I would consider the luck and I'll consider the fact that I had really good you know supportive teachers in school lucky. You know that was a guarantee if I had gone to those schools... But the fact that I managed to actually meet them they noticed me and they helped me. I'd consider that luck and so I know I guess luck can come in all shapes and sizes and forms. But as long as it's an event or stimulus that that basically ends up benefiting you in the end. Thhen yeah I'd consider that lucky.

Q: Does it need to be unlikely?

AI think more often than not it will be something that's unlikely because I mean otherwise everyone would be lucky. But I think on the whole luck can come in like various shapes and sizes it can be something as small as you know your teacher helping you uh apply or your teacher helping you get involved with the political party which then later on may or may not have helped in your application to go to university. And it could have been as big as you know parents getting divorced and being forced to move countries. So you know it can be it can be a little event it can be a big event but obviously all of these events coming together they kind of help where you are.

23_3

Codes:
- 2nd generation
- Lack of control: lack of control
- Lottery of birth

Content:

Yeah, honestly the biggest aspect of luck is the luck of birth... Because all these things, that I was able to come back after my depressive period, to get proper treatment to my [medical condition] and have this provision setup for me. It's all a matter of time and money... In a more comfortable situation you have a lot more... Also like... I guess, I think... Hmm... I guess I would say that also, the amount of diligence I have is also something I was born with, safety to say so... Yeah, the biggest luck factor is... Where... In what family, how...

Q: Do you have a definition of luck you can give to the researchers?

A: I guess luck in positive and negative sense, circumstances under not your control.